

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GREECE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Across Greece, communities find that a place they depend on — a forest on the Halkidiki peninsula, a river valley, a Natura 2000 wetland, an Aegean island, the sea off Crete — has been opened to something destructive. An open-pit and underground mine. A large tourist resort inside a protected area. A river diversion. A wind or solar development sited without care. Hydrocarbon exploration. A landfill or an incinerator. The first sign is often the machinery, the survey stakes, a notice that the "environmental terms" of a project have been approved, or the sudden appearance of a spatial plan that rezones a coastline.

This guide is a practical manual for those communities. It explains how the approval system for large projects works in Greece, where the genuine — and, thanks to European Union membership, unusually strong — openings are, what documentation matters, how to organise, and how to use the levers that have here delivered real victories. It does not promise that any project can be stopped. It offers a clear-eyed method that gives you the best possible chance.

Greece, like several countries in this guide, holds two truths at once, and you must carry both. The first is genuinely hopeful. **Greece's courts and EU law have stopped major destructive projects.** The decades-long plan to divert the Acheloos River — moving water across the Pindos mountains with vast ecological and social cost — was overturned again and again by Greece's supreme administrative court, the Council of State, and finally found by the Court of Justice of the European Union to breach EU water, habitats and assessment law. That is proof that in Greece a community, its lawyers, and the EU together can defeat even a project that successive governments treated as a priority.

The second truth is sobering. **A determined project with state and financial backing can grind through even a fierce, sustained resistance.** The Skouries gold and copper mine in Halkidiki drew one of Europe's most committed community movements — years of protest, occupation, and litigation from 2012 onward — yet the project was re-approved in 2021, financed, and built, and is entering production. The resistance did not stop it: economic crisis eroded the movement, the state stayed aligned with the investor, and protest itself was met with heavy policing and prosecutions. Greece shows both what the levers can win and where they can fail.

Which of these situations you face shapes everything. But both share a decisive feature most of the world's communities lack: **Greece is a member state of the European Union**, bound by EU environmental law that its own government cannot lawfully override, with an independent supreme administrative court that applies that law, and answerable to the European Commission and the Court of Justice. That combination is the most powerful fact in this guide.

The Strategic Framework

The core idea is simple: **a destructive project is not a single event but a chain of decisions and dependencies, and a chain can be broken at its weakest link.** A project needs its environmental terms approved; it needs to survive the EU nature and impact rules; it needs to pass the scrutiny of the Council of State within a short, strict deadline; it needs the acquiescence of a public that in Greece has often refused to give it; and it needs to avoid the attention of Brussels, the courts, the press, and the anti-corruption bodies. Each is a potential point of leverage.

Your task is to find the link you can reach. Sometimes it is the environmental permit and the EIA. Sometimes it is the Natura 2000 status and the Habitats Directive's appropriate-assessment rule. Sometimes it is the Water Framework Directive, as at Acheloos. Sometimes it is the Council of State, or the European Commission, or a preliminary reference to the CJEU. And sometimes — as in Greece's long history of environmental struggle — it is the sustained, disciplined weight of a mobilised public.

Critical Caveat: Which Situation Are You In?

Throughout this guide you will find honest assessments, because a guide that promised any project can be stopped by the right petition would be lying.

Where the project depends on an environmental approval you can challenge on EU-law grounds, and a court or the Commission can be reached, Greece's tools are real and have won — Acheloos is the proof.

Where the state and a well-financed investor are determined, the economy is pressing jobs, and the movement is being worn down or policed, the fight is far harder — Skouries is the warning. There the levers still matter, but so do endurance, breadth, the EU dimension, and a clear-eyed view of the odds.

Knowing which situation you are in is among the most important judgments you will make, and much of this guide is designed to help you judge accurately.

How to use this guide

Read the whole thing once before acting, and read the legal, tilted-system, and organising sections with care, because in Greece the short court deadlines, the EU dimension, and the risk of a movement being worn down shape everything. Two principles run throughout. First, **use the European lever**: because Greece is bound by EU environmental law and its Council of State applies that law and can refer questions to the CJEU, your strongest moves are usually the ones that engage those obligations. Second, **combine the strands**: documentation, EU and domestic legal action, organising, media, and mass mobilisation work far better together than any one alone. That combination is how Acheloos was won — and its absence is part of how Skouries was lost.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pressure a chain you cannot see. This section maps the bodies that decide, the journey a project takes, the rules that matter — Greek and, crucially, European — the incentives that drive decisions, and the overseers who can hold the system to account.

The Bodies That Decide

The Ministry of Environment and Energy and the decentralised administrations. Environmental permitting for major projects runs through the Ministry of Environment and Energy for the largest projects, and through the regional decentralised administrations for others. They conduct the environmental-impact assessment (EIA) procedure and issue — or refuse — the **Approval of Environmental Terms (AEPO)**, the central permit a project needs. This is your first and most important formal arena: the AEPO is the document the whole project rests on, and it is challengeable.

The Council of State (Symvoulío tis Epikrateias). Greece's supreme administrative court, and the single most important body in this guide. It hears petitions for annulment (aitisi akiroseos) of the AEPO and of spatial plans, applying Greek and EU law. It has annulled major projects — the Acheloos diversion, again and again — and it can refer questions to the Court of Justice of the European Union. It has also upheld projects, including at Skouries. It is a real, powerful, but not guaranteed lever, and it operates under a **strict, short deadline** you must not miss.

Local and regional authorities. Municipalities and regions adopt spatial and land-use plans, issue local approvals, and often stand to gain — or lose — from a project. A municipality can itself petition the Council of State, and local plans that

rezone a coast or a forest are frequently a project's first enabling step.

The forest and archaeological authorities. Greece's forest service governs interventions in forest land, and its archaeological service protects antiquities — both can be points of leverage where a project touches protected forest or heritage.

The anti-corruption and prosecuting bodies. Greece's prosecutors and anti-corruption authorities can pursue genuine corruption in permitting and public works, and the Greek Ombudsman (Synigoros tou Politi) can investigate maladministration.

The European Union institutions. This is what sets Greece apart. The **European Commission** enforces EU environmental law against Greece and receives complaints from anyone. The **Court of Justice of the European Union (CJEU)** is the ultimate enforcer, and the Council of State can — and sometimes must — refer questions to it, as it did over Acheloos. These are bodies no local mayor or investor can capture.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

Stage 1 — Plans and siting. A project appears in a spatial plan, a special development plan, or a concession. Changes to these plans, often little-noticed, are where a project first becomes possible.

Stage 2 — The environmental procedure and the AEPO. Significant projects require an EIA and public consultation, after which the authority issues or refuses the Approval of Environmental Terms. This is the decisive formal stage — and the stage whose approval you challenge at the Council of State.

Stage 3 — Permits and construction. Building, forest, water and other permits follow, then construction. Each is a document with conditions, and each is a potential point of challenge or of enforcement.

Stage 4 — Operation and harm. Pollution, habitat loss, water impacts, and their effects on people and livelihoods follow — the toll that documentation must capture.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Matter

You need not be a lawyer, but you must know the handful of instruments that give your case its force. In Greece the European ones are often the strongest:

- **EU environmental law**, which binds Greece directly: the **Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) Directive**; the **Habitats and Birds Directives** and the **Natura 2000** network, whose Article 6(3) requires a strict "appropriate assessment" of plans and projects affecting protected sites; the **Water Framework Directive**, on which the Acheloos diversion was struck down; and the **Strategic Environmental Assessment Directive** for plans. A breach is enforceable by the Commission and the CJEU.
- **The Aarhus Convention**, binding on Greece and the EU, guaranteeing access to environmental information, public participation, and access to justice.
- **Greek environmental law** — the framework law on environmental licensing (Law 4014/2011 and successors) and the constitutional protection of the environment (Article 24 of the Greek Constitution), which the Council of State has used robustly.
- **Greek forest and antiquities law**, protecting forest land and heritage.

The pattern to hold in mind: Greek authorities may lean toward a project, but **EU environmental law is a ceiling they cannot lawfully breach**, and the Council of State, the Commission and the CJEU exist to enforce it. That is your firmest ground — though, as Skouries shows, firm ground is not the same as certain victory.

Follow the Money — Why Projects Proceed

Understand the incentives and you understand the pressure. Governments want investment and jobs, especially after years of economic crisis; regions and municipalities want revenue; investors and their financiers — including, at Skouries, international banks and development funds — want returns. The environmental and social cost falls on communities and on shared natural heritage. That is why the European lever matters so much: the Commission and the CJEU are referees the local beneficiaries cannot capture, and the Council of State, though domestic, is independent.

The Overseers — Who Can Hold the System to Account

- **The Council of State**, which reviews permits and plans and applies EU law.
- **The European Commission**, which receives complaints and can open infringement proceedings against Greece.

- **The Court of Justice of the European Union**, the ultimate enforcer, reachable through the Council of State's references.
- **The Greek Ombudsman (Synigoros tou Politi)**, for maladministration.
- **Prosecutors**, for genuine corruption.
- **Greek and international NGOs** — WWF Greece, Greenpeace Greece, MedINA, Callisto and others — who investigate, litigate, and carry cases to Brussels.

These are the overseers your strategy must reach. Much of the rest of this guide is about building a case strong enough to move them — above all the courts and the European ones.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns from how Greek and comparable EU campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variable is not fully in the table: **how determined the state and the investor are, and whether the economy is being used to press the project through**. For an ordinary approval you can challenge on EU-law grounds, Greece's tools are strong and have won; against a flagship project with government and financial backing, discount the figures, lean hardest on the European lever and endurance, and be clear-eyed — Skouries shows that even a fierce movement can lose.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–10%	1–3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Public participation in the EIA	20–40%	during review	low	On record; conditions or a redo
AEPO / EIA challenge (Council of State)	30–50%	12–48 months	moderate	Approval annulled; process redone; delay
Natura 2000 / appropriate-assessment challenge	35–55%	12–48 months	moderate	Consent quashed on Habitats-Directive grounds
Water Framework challenge (the Acheloos ground)	35–55%	12–48 months	moderate	Consent quashed on water-law grounds
European Commission complaint (EU infringement)	25–50%	12–48 months	low	Scrutiny of the state; pressure; leverage
Anti-corruption referral (prosecutors / Ombudsman)	10–30%	12–48 months	low	Investigation; a project's protection removed
Mass, disciplined public mobilisation	20–45%	6–36 months	low	Political retreat; a plan withdrawn
All steps combined (challengeable approval)	45–60%	12–48 months	low–moderate	Stopped, redesigned, or delayed
All steps combined (flagship, state-backed)	15–35%	12–48 months	low–moderate	Delayed, exposed, conditioned; rarely stopped

Key insight: all steps together beat any single one, and Greece's real strengths are unusual — **binding EU environmental law** (EIA, Habitats/Natura 2000, Water Framework) the state cannot override; an **independent supreme court**, the Council of State, that applies that law and has struck down major projects; the **European Commission and CJEU** as referees local interests cannot capture; and a **deep tradition of grassroots resistance**. Its constraints are a **short, strict court deadline, state alignment with big investors, economic pressure that erodes movements**, and, at flashpoints, the **policing and prosecution of protest**.

A note on cost: participating, documenting, and complaining to the Commission are inexpensive. The expenditure that changes outcomes is a lawyer experienced in EU and administrative environmental law — available through Greece's environmental NGOs (WWF Greece, Greenpeace Greece) and European partners — engaged early, because the Council of State deadline is short.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (stopped, redesigned, or delayed)

CHALLENGEABLE APPROVAL -- EU-law grounds, Council of State reachable, legal support:

All steps combined:	45-60%
Natura 2000 / Water challenge:	35-55%
EU Commission complaint:	25-50%
Mass mobilisation:	20-45%
Single step:	5-40%

FLAGSHIP, STATE-BACKED PROJECT -- financed, jobs-driven, protest policed:

All steps combined:	15-35%
EU-law challenge:	the strongest single lever
Delay / conditions:	more achievable than an outright stop
Single step:	5-25%

How to read this honestly. The arguments that move outcomes in Greece are **legal and EU-anchored, reinforced by mobilisation and scrutiny** — a defective EIA, a Natura 2000 breach, a Water Framework violation — carried to the Council of State within its deadline and, decisively, to the European Commission. Acheloos shows the ceiling: the courts and EU law, used relentlessly over decades, defeated a project every government wanted. Skouries shows the floor: where the state, the investor, and economic pressure align and protest is worn down and policed, even a committed movement can lose. Most Greek fights sit between them, and the honest lesson is that the levers are real and have won, but they are not certain.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **EU environmental law and the Council of State** — the AEPO, Natura 2000, and Water Framework grounds, carried to the supreme court within its deadline, and referred to the CJEU where the law is unclear.
2. **The European Commission** — the complaint to Brussels that a captured or determined domestic process cannot deflect.
3. **Mass, disciplined public mobilisation** — the grassroots weight that can force a political retreat, sustained over the long haul.
4. **Documentation** — the record that every court and referee acts on.
5. **Media, NGOs, and the anti-corruption bodies** — the scrutiny that raises the cost and removes a project's protection.

What Greek Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The courts and EU law can win** — the Acheloos diversion was overturned repeatedly by the Council of State and struck down by the CJEU under the Water Framework and Habitats Directives, and Greek NGOs have annulled plans that allowed resorts inside Natura 2000 islands. **But determination can prevail** — Skouries, opposed for over a decade, was re-approved, financed, and built as the crisis eroded the movement and the state stood with the investor. **Deadlines and procedure are decisive** — the Council of State's short annulment window is unforgiving, so act at once. **The EU lever reaches furthest** — a documented breach of an EU directive is your firmest ground and your route past domestic capture. **And endurance matters** — the wins came from relentless, sustained pressure over years. The through-line: **build the EU-law case, file at the Council of State on time, complain to the Commission, organise broadly, and sustain it — because in Greece persistence and the European lever are what win.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Before you gather a neighbour or write a word, you must know exactly what you are facing, who decides, where the chain is weakest, and how determined the other side is. Acting before you know these things wastes effort. Spend your first days answering five questions.

The Five Questions

1. What exactly is the project, and where is it in the environmental procedure? A mine, resort, river diversion, wind or solar development, hydrocarbon project, landfill or incinerator — and has the EIA been done, is the Approval of Environmental Terms (AEPO) issued or still pending, is the public consultation open? The AEPO is the spine of the project; knowing exactly where it stands tells you whether you are objecting, challenging, or enforcing.

2. Does it affect a Natura 2000 site, protected forest, or water body? This is often the strongest question in Greece. A project affecting a Natura 2000 site triggers the Habitats Directive's strict appropriate assessment; one affecting a river or water body engages the Water Framework Directive, on which Acheloos was struck down. If a protected site, forest, or water body is engaged, EU law is directly in play.

3. How determined are the state and the investor? Be honest. Is this an ordinary regional project, or a flagship the government treats as a priority, backed by powerful financiers and framed as jobs and investment? The Skouries lesson is that determination and economic pressure can overcome even a fierce movement — so gauge the force you are up against, and plan for a long fight if it is a flagship.

4. Who decides, and who benefits? Which authority issues the AEPO — the Ministry or a decentralised administration? Which spatial plan enabled it? Who profits, and is there any sign of corruption? Map the decision-makers and beneficiaries; it tells you which lever, and whether the anti-corruption bodies belong in your plan.

5. What is the deadline, and what is the risk to protesters? The Council of State's annulment window is short (measured in weeks from publication), so identify it immediately. And judge the climate for protest: Greece is a functioning democracy and organising is generally safe, but flashpoints like Skouries have seen heavy policing, arrests, and even prosecutions of activists — so plan lawful, disciplined action and legal support in advance.

Reading the Answers

Work the five questions together and a picture forms. **An ordinary project affecting a Natura 2000 site or water body, with the AEPO recently issued** points toward the EIA and appropriate-assessment challenge at the Council of State, filed on time, plus a European Commission complaint — the strongest configuration in Greece. **A flagship, state-backed project** points toward the same legal levers but demands endurance, breadth, the EU dimension, and realistic expectations. **A project driven by a spatial plan** points toward challenging the plan itself. **In every case**, the EU lever is available and usually decisive, and mobilisation can transform a fight — as Greece's long history of resistance shows.

Naming Your Realistic Goal

Before going further, decide with a small, trusted group what winning would mean — concretely and honestly. Depending on your situation, a realistic goal might be: annulment of the AEPO at the Council of State; a Natura 2000 or Water Framework breach found and the project quashed; a European Commission finding against the state; a plan withdrawn under public pressure; delay and redesign that make a project uneconomic; or, against a flagship, conditions, delay, and a durable movement even where an outright stop proves out of reach. Acheloos shows that stopping is genuinely possible; Skouries shows it is not guaranteed. A goal that fits your situation, anchored in EU law and sustained over time, is the responsible one.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation is the foundation of everything that follows. In Greece — where the Council of State, the European Commission, and the CJEU all act on evidence — the campaign is won or lost on whether you can show, in dated, sourced, organised form, exactly what is happening, what rule it breaks, and what harm it does. A community that can prove a defective EIA, a Natura 2000 breach, or a Water Framework violation holds the instrument that moves the strongest overseers. A community with only anger has far less.

The Mindset: Build a Record for a Court and for Brussels

Approach documentation as if you are assembling a file that a Council of State judge and a European Commission case-handler will read — people who act on concrete, provable facts tied to specific legal obligations. Everything must be dated, attributed to a source, and stored securely in more than one place, including with trusted allies. Frame it around the rules from Section 2: the EIA, the Habitats Directive and Natura 2000, the Water Framework Directive, and the Greek constitutional protection of the environment. Evidence tied to an EU obligation is the most powerful evidence you can gather.

What to Document

The project and its AEPO. What is proposed, by whom, and exactly where it stands — EIA, public consultation, the Approval of Environmental Terms, the operating permits. Obtain the documents; the gaps and defects in them are often your case, and the AEPO's publication date starts the Council of State clock.

The environmental and Natura 2000 impact. The habitats and species affected, the Natura 2000 boundaries and their standard data forms, the water bodies engaged, and whether an appropriate assessment was done and done honestly. For a forest or a river, document the ecological value and any protected status — the heart of the European case.

The harm. Deforestation, pollution, water impacts, effects on tourism and livelihoods, cumulative effects — captured with dates and locations, and with imagery where possible.

The procedure. Whether the public consultation was genuine and timely, whether the EIA addressed what the law requires, whether publicity and deadline rules were met. Procedural defects are among the most reliable grounds at the Council of State — and the CJEU has scrutinised exactly how Greece publicises approvals and starts the challenge clock.

The decision chain and any corruption. The spatial-plan changes, the approvals, the beneficiaries, and — documented only from solid sources — any sign of corruption in permitting or public works.

How to Document Safely and Credibly

Record dates and sources for everything; prefer official documents, imagery, and verifiable data over rumour; and be accurate and restrained, because a file that overstates can be dismissed and, in a defamation-prone environment, can expose you. Use satellite and remote imagery — freely available tools document deforestation and construction without confrontation. **On safety: Greece is a functioning democracy and organising is generally safe, but flashpoints have seen heavy policing and the prosecution of activists — so at a contested site, act lawfully and in numbers, keep documentation to what is safe and legal, and line up legal support in advance.** Partner early with Greece's environmental NGOs and their European allies: they bring the legal framing, the investigative capacity, and the channels to the Council of State and the Commission, and can carry the heavier work.

Reading a Greek EIA for Its Weak Points

When you obtain the environmental-impact study, read it like an opponent looking for the seams, because that is where your case lives. A handful of weaknesses recur, and Greek and EU case law has turned on each. **The appropriate assessment** — where a Natura 2000 site is affected — is the first thing to test: was one done, did it honestly assess the effect on the site's protected habitats and species, or does it wave the impact away? A missing or superficial appropriate assessment is among the strongest grounds under the Habitats Directive. **The water analysis** is the second, and it is Greece's signature ground: does the study honestly assess the effect on rivers and water bodies against the Water Framework Directive, or does it rest, as Acheloos did, on inadequate and outdated data? **The Natura 2000 boundaries** themselves are worth checking — the Council of State has heard arguments that an EIA misstated which protected sites fell within a project's area. **The alternatives and cumulative effects** are the fourth: has the study considered doing less, or nothing, and added this project to the others burdening the same forest, coast, or river? **The consultation and publicity** are the fifth: was the public genuinely informed and heard, and was the approval published so that the challenge deadline ran fairly? Each weakness is both an objection to lodge and a ground to take to the Council of State — and, where it breaches an EU directive, a line in your complaint to Brussels.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This section turns documentation into a concrete list of sources. Much of Greece's environmental record is public, and the EU dimension adds powerful sources a determined domestic body cannot suppress. Work through these carefully.

The Official and Legal Record

The environmental procedure file. The EIA, the public-consultation record, and the Approval of Environmental Terms are published through the environmental-licensing system; request the full file, including the impact study and any appropriate assessment. Note the AEPO's publication date — it starts the short Council of State deadline. The defects in these documents are frequently the case.

The spatial and land-use plans. The regions and municipalities hold the plans; a rezoning is often the project's first enabling step, and the plan itself can be challenged, as WWF Greece has challenged plans permitting resorts inside Natura 2000 islands.

The permits and authorisations. Building, forest, water and other approvals, each with conditions you can hold the project to.

Environmental-information requests. Under the Aarhus-based right of access to environmental information, you can compel disclosure of studies, approvals, monitoring data, and correspondence — and a refusal is itself challengeable.

The Nature and Water Sources

Natura 2000 data. The Natura 2000 boundaries and standard data forms establish what is protected and what is at stake — central to the Habitats-Directive case.

Water-body status. River-basin management plans and water-body classifications establish the Water Framework Directive picture — the ground on which Acheloos was struck down.

Satellite and monitoring data. Global Forest Watch and satellite imagery document deforestation and construction over time, safely and verifiably.

The Company and Corruption Record

Company and ownership records. The Greek business registry (GEMI) shows who owns and directs a company; cross-border tools (OpenCorporates) trace parents and links. Public-procurement records reveal contracts.

The corruption record. Prosecutions, Ombudsman findings, and investigative journalism document any corruption in permitting or public works.

The Organisations and Channels That Carry the Case

- **Greek environmental NGOs** — WWF Greece, Greenpeace Greece, MedINA, Callisto, and local movements such as the Halkidiki committees — who investigate, litigate, and complain to Brussels.
- **European partners** — ClientEarth, the European Environmental Bureau, and others — who bring EU-law expertise and carry cases to the Commission.
- **The European Commission's environmental complaint channel**, open to anyone, and the **Aarhus Convention Compliance Committee**.
- **Investigative journalists**, Greek and international, who have made these fights visible.

Turning Sources into a Case

As you gather, sort everything against the chain from Section 2 — the plan, the EIA, the AEPO, the Natura 2000 and water status, the operation, the harm — so each piece attaches to the point and the legal obligation it proves, and note every relevant deadline. By the end you should be able to show, with dated and sourced evidence, what is happening, what EU and Greek rule it breaks, and at what cost — the record that moves the Council of State and the European Commission, and that, at Acheloos, moved the CJEU.

Researchers for Hire, and Everyday Research Tools

If digging through corporate filings, agency files and environmental records is beyond a few volunteers, you can hire it out — and this lifts a real weight off novice activists. The field is **opposition research** (or, on the labour side, **corporate-campaign research** — the same methods unions use to expose an employer's finances and record, turned on a developer). For your side, seek **opposition-research firms**, **licensed private investigators** with paid records access, **investigative journalists and freelancers** (often the cheapest, and they publish what they find), **environmental-compliance auditors** to dissect a developer's regulatory record, and **public-records / freedom-of-information specialists** to pry files loose. The investigative tools they use — and that a determined activist can use directly — include **OpenCorporates** and **OCCRP Aleph** (company ownership and cross-border links, worldwide) and **DocumentCloud** (search and OCR large document dumps), with **SEC EDGAR**, **LittleSis** and **MuckRock** as United States examples; most countries have their own equivalents.

For everyday, subject-agnostic research, a small kit goes far: **AI assistants** — Claude.ai, ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and Perplexity for sourced answers — are excellent for explaining a law, summarising a document, or drafting, so long as you **always verify** what they tell you, because they can invent citations; **Google Scholar** and Google's advanced search operators for studies and buried files; and the **Wayback Machine** for pages a developer or agency has quietly deleted.

Making the European Complaint Count

The complaint to the European Commission is one of Greece's firmest levers, so it is worth making well. It is free, open to anyone, and requires no lawyer — but a strong complaint does several things a weak one does not. It names the **specific EU directive** breached — the EIA Directive, the Habitats or Birds Directive, the Water Framework Directive — rather than complaining in general terms. It **evidences the breach** with dated documents, maps, the Natura 2000 data forms, and imagery, so the case-handler can see it is real. It shows that the **domestic route has been tried or is inadequate** — an objection lodged, a Council of State petition filed or blocked by the deadline — because the Commission expects that. And it **frames the harm as a failure of the Greek state to meet its EU obligations**, which is what the Commission

acts on. Route the complaint through, or alongside, an experienced NGO — WWF Greece, ClientEarth, the European Environmental Bureau — which knows how the Commission works. A single complaint will not stop a project overnight; infringement is slow. But it puts the weight of Europe behind your case, reaches past domestic determination, and — with the Council of State petition — is one of the two arenas that matter most in Greece.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documentation gives you a case; organisation gives it weight. Greece has a deep tradition of environmental resistance, and its history offers both inspiration and a hard lesson: breadth and endurance can win, but a movement worn down by time, economic pressure, and policing can lose. This section is about building resistance that is broad, disciplined, EU-anchored, and durable.

Start With a Small, Trusted Core

Begin with a handful of committed people who share the load and can act without drama. Agree early on what you are trying to achieve, who does what, and — given the short court deadlines — who is responsible for finding a lawyer and filing on time. Agree, too, on discipline and safety: at a contested site, lawful and collective action, with legal support arranged in advance.

Widen Into a Broad, Disciplined Coalition

Greece's strongest movements widened a local fight into a national cause. Aim for the same shape. **Local residents and community committees** are the moral core, as the Halkidiki committees were. **National environmental NGOs** — WWF Greece, Greenpeace Greece, MedINA, Callisto — bring investigation, litigation, and the channel to the European Commission. **European partners** bring EU-law firepower. **Scientists, ecologists and hydrologists** supply the evidence. **Municipalities and regions**, which can themselves petition the Council of State, are powerful allies. **Sympathetic journalists** carry it to the country. Breadth is what turns a village fight into a force the state must weigh.

The Distinctive Greek Lever — and Its Limit

Greece has a powerful tradition of mass mobilisation, and sustained, disciplined public pressure has forced political retreats. But Skouries is the cautionary tale: a fierce movement can be worn down over years by economic crisis, the promise of jobs, and the steady pressure of policing and prosecution. So mobilise — but plan for endurance. Build the coalition wide enough and the finances and legal footing solid enough to outlast a long fight, and pair the public pressure always with the legal and EU levers, which do not tire as a crowd can.

Choose Tactics That Fit — and Stay Safe

Greece's repertoire is wide: public participation in the EIA, petitions, lawful demonstrations, coalition-building, media, litigation at the Council of State, and the European complaint, used together. Keep it lawful and disciplined — at flashpoints, a single act of violence hands the state the story and the justification for a crackdown. Protect the most exposed: Skouries saw activists arrested and prosecuted, so arrange legal support in advance, share risk, and never let anyone face the police or the courts alone. Guard against the burnout and division that a long fight breeds, by sharing the load, celebrating milestones, and keeping the legal case moving even when the streets are quiet.

Endurance, breadth, discipline, and the EU lever are how Greek communities have prevailed — and their absence, at Skouries, is part of how a fierce resistance was ground down. Build to last.

Hiring Help to Run the Campaign

You need not carry the whole campaign yourselves. A whole industry runs opposition campaigns for hire — the visible turnout at hearings, the public comment, the messaging and the media — known as **grassroots-for-hire** or **public-affairs / grassroots-advocacy** consulting. It usually serves whoever pays, most often the deep-pocketed side, but you can hire the same muscle for yours: **public-interest communications and PR firms, campaign and field-organising firms** that run turnout and canvassing, and, if the fight becomes a local vote, **ballot-measure consultants**. People outside that niche can carry a piece too — a **PR or crisis-communications firm, a campaign consultant, a digital-advocacy shop**, or a seasoned **community organiser** — taking weight off exhausted volunteers who feel they are carrying the opposition alone. Two rules hold. Hire them **transparently**, and never let anyone fake a grassroots front: that is *astroturfing* — dishonest, and ruinous if exposed; the aim is to amplify a real community, not fabricate one. And mind

your **setting** — where public campaigning is repressed or dangerous this market may be absent and a visible "show" perilous, so favour trusted journalists and international allies over hired campaigners, and never let paid help expose your people.

Building a Movement That Lasts

The hardest lesson Greece teaches is about endurance, and it is worth dwelling on because it is where the fiercest movements have failed. Acheloos was won over decades; Skouries was lost, in part, because a committed movement was worn down over years by economic crisis, the pull of scarce jobs, and the grinding pressure of policing and prosecution. A Greek campaign must therefore be built not for a burst but for a long haul, and that changes how you organise from the start.

Share the load so no one burns out. A fight carried by two or three exhausted people collapses when they do. Spread roles — documentation, legal liaison, media, turnout, fundraising — across enough people that any one can step back without the campaign stopping, and bring in new people continually so the effort renews rather than depletes.

Keep the legal case moving even when the streets are quiet. A crowd tires; a court petition does not. The great advantage of the EU-law and Council of State route is that it works in the slow months when public energy is low, so keep it advancing steadily — the deadline met, the complaint filed, the evidence deepening — so the campaign is never idle even when it is not visible.

Anticipate the economic argument, because it is the one that erodes movements. At Skouries, the promise of jobs in a region starved of them wore down the will to resist. Do not pretend the economic pull away; meet it. Document the jobs the project actually delivers versus what is promised — at Skouries, of thousands present on site, only a few hundred were directly employed by the operator — and make the honest case that a forest, a river, or a coast is an economy too, for tourism, fishing, farming, and the generations after.

Protect your people where protest is policed. Greece is a democracy and organising is generally safe, but flashpoints have seen arrests and prosecutions, so arrange legal support in advance, keep action lawful and collective, and never let anyone face the police or the courts alone. A movement that looks after its people lasts; one that lets its bravest be picked off does not.

Mark the milestones. Over a multi-year fight, name and celebrate the wins along the way — a petition filed, a hearing survived, a Commission complaint lodged, a plan delayed — so the community feels progress and stays in the fight. Endurance is not grim persistence alone; it is a movement that renews its own morale.

Build this way and you give your campaign the one quality that, in Greece, has most often decided the outcome: the staying power to keep the levers working until they do.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Legal action in Greece is a genuine and powerful lever, and its distinctive strength is that it runs on two tracks at once — the domestic Council of State and the European Union. This section explains the openings. It is not a substitute for a lawyer, and finding one experienced in EU and administrative environmental law — often through Greece's environmental NGOs or European partners — is an early and vital task, because the deadline is short.

The Domestic Openings

Challenging the AEPO and the EIA at the Council of State. The core domestic route: a petition for annulment (aitisi akiroseos) of the Approval of Environmental Terms, on the ground that the EIA was inadequate, the public consultation defective, or the legal requirements unmet. **The deadline is short — measured in weeks from the approval's publication — and strict**, so identify the publication date at once and file on time. This court has annulled major projects; it is your central arena.

The Natura 2000 / appropriate-assessment challenge. Where a project affects a Natura 2000 site, the Habitats Directive requires a strict appropriate assessment, and a consent granted without a proper one is vulnerable. This is among the strongest grounds in Greece, and Greek NGOs have used it to strike down plans permitting development inside protected sites.

The Water Framework challenge. Where a project affects a river or water body — a diversion, a dam, a large abstraction — the Water Framework Directive is powerful ground; it is the basis on which the Acheloos diversion was repeatedly overturned.

Challenging the plan. The spatial or land-use plan that enabled the project can itself be challenged where it was adopted unlawfully.

The European Track — Greece's Firmest Ground

The complaint to the European Commission. Anyone can complain to the Commission that Greece is breaching EU environmental law — the EIA, Habitats, Birds, or Water Framework Directives. The Commission can open **infringement proceedings** and ultimately refer the state to the **Court of Justice of the European Union**. This is a lever no local authority or investor can neutralise.

Preliminary references to the CJEU. The Council of State can — and sometimes must — refer a question of EU law to the CJEU, whose ruling binds the outcome. It did exactly this over Acheloos, and the CJEU's ruling that the diversion breached EU water and habitats law was decisive. Asking the court to refer a genuine EU-law question is a powerful move.

Aarhus access to justice. The Aarhus Convention guarantees the public and environmental NGOs access to the courts in environmental matters, and its Compliance Committee can be petitioned where access is denied.

Standing, Deadlines, and Realistic Expectations

Three points. First, **standing**: affected individuals, municipalities, and environmental NGOs have broad standing before the Council of State, so let an NGO or a municipality carry the case where it can. Second, **the deadline is the thing that most often defeats a good case** — it is short and strict, so treat filing on time as the campaign's first legal priority. Third, **be realistic**: the Council of State has annulled major projects (Acheloos) and upheld others (Skouries, the Crete hydrocarbon approval). A strong EU-law ground, filed on time, is your best chance — but against a determined, well-financed, state-backed project, litigation may win delay, conditions, and a redo rather than an outright stop.

What Legal Action Realistically Achieves

Be clear-eyed. Domestic litigation can annul an AEPO, quash a consent on Natura 2000 or Water Framework grounds, and strike down an unlawful plan. The European track can bring the Commission and the CJEU against the state itself, reaching past domestic determination — as it did at Acheloos. Combined with documentation, organisation, media, and sustained mobilisation, legal action on both tracks is the substantive path in Greece. Treat the Council of State and the European Commission as your two strongest arenas, run them together, file on time, and remember that this is the country whose courts and EU law defeated a river diversion every government wanted — even as it is also the country where Skouries was built.

The Acheloos Precedent — How the Courts and EU Law Won

The single most important case for a Greek community to know is the Acheloos River diversion, because it shows exactly how the levers in this guide combine to win. The plan — to divert water from the Acheloos in western Greece across the Pindos mountains to the Thessaly plain, with dams, tunnels and vast ecological and social cost — was treated as a national priority by government after government. And it was defeated, not by one dramatic act, but by relentless, patient use of the law over decades. The Council of State overturned the project again and again — in 1994, 2000, and 2005 — each time on environmental and assessment grounds. When the government tried to legislate around the court, the Council of State refused to be circumvented and, in 2009, referred the case to the Court of Justice of the European Union, submitting fourteen questions of EU law. The CJEU's 2012 ruling was decisive: the way the diversion was planned breached EU law — the Water Framework, Habitats, EIA and Strategic Environmental Assessment Directives — resting on inadequate, outdated data and ignoring the minimum legal requirements for water management. When you build your case, build it as the Acheloos litigants did: on specific, evidenced breaches of binding EU directives, carried to the Council of State and, where the law is unclear, referred to the CJEU. It is the proven Greek route, and it defeated a project every government wanted.

The Deadline Is the Thing: Guard the Clock

If you take one practical lesson from this guide, take this: in Greece the short, strict deadline for challenging an approval at the Council of State defeats more good cases than any weakness of argument. When the Approval of Environmental Terms is published — and Greek law treats publication on the designated official website as putting every interested party on notice — a clock starts, measured in weeks, not months. Miss it, and even an unlawful approval can stand. The CJEU has scrutinised this very mechanism — whether posting a decision online can be treated as full knowledge for the purpose of the challenge deadline — which tells you how consequential, and how contested, the clock is. So make guarding it someone's explicit job. The moment a project appears, find out whether and when the AEPO has been or will be published.

The moment it is published, note the date and count the deadline. Engage a lawyer or an environmental NGO immediately, not after you have finished organising, because the petition must be drafted and filed within the window. And if you are close to the deadline with an incomplete case, file a protective petition on the strongest ground you have and refine it — a filed case can be developed; a missed deadline cannot be undone.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a Council of State judge, a European Commission case-handler, a journalist, a mayor, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a project's environmental study never properly assessed its effect on a Natura 2000 site it borders. That one fact becomes:

- **An EU-law argument:** the approval breaches the Habitats Directive's requirement of an appropriate assessment — a matter for the Council of State and, if referred, the CJEU, and a complaint to the European Commission.
- **A domestic legal argument:** the AEPO is unlawful for want of a lawful assessment, and can be annulled at the Council of State — if you file within the deadline.
- **A constitutional argument:** the approval offends Article 24 of the Greek Constitution's protection of the environment, which the Council of State takes seriously.
- **A political argument:** the state is failing its own protected sites and its European obligations, at risk of EU infringement and cost.
- **A media and public argument:** a protected habitat is being sacrificed to a project the community never accepted — a story with resonance in a country with a long environmental conscience.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The Council of State wants the breach framed against the specific legal requirement — the EIA, the appropriate assessment, the Water Framework obligations, the consultation rules — with the documents that prove it, and filed on time.

The European Commission wants a clear, documented breach of a specific EU directive by the Greek state, with evidence and a demonstration that the domestic route has failed or is inadequate.

Journalists and the public want the human and natural story made vivid and true — the forest, the river, the island, the community's defiance — grounded in fact.

Local and national officials want to know the legal and financial risk — annulment, EU infringement, reputational cost — and the political cost of a mobilised public.

The Master Frame: "This Breaks Europe's Law — and Greek Courts Have Struck Such Projects Down"

Across every audience, the strongest frame in Greece joins the legal to the proven: this project breaches Greek and, above all, European law; the Council of State applies that law and can refer it to the CJEU; and Greece is the country whose courts and EU law defeated the Acheloos diversion after decades of effort. Framing the fight this way is accurate; it is legally powerful, engaging the domestic and European tracks at once; and it carries the authority of a court that has struck such projects down. In Greece, insisting — with evidence, and on time — that the law has been broken, and that Europe is watching, is your strongest argument.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media turns a local objection into a national cause and a cost the powerful must weigh — and Greece has a strong tradition of environmental journalism and a public that responds to these fights. Use media deliberately, in service of your goal,

alongside the legal and organising work beneath it.

What Coverage Achieves

Coverage raises the political and reputational cost of a project; it pressures officials who dislike scrutiny; it reaches allies, experts, and lawyers; it warns investors and financiers — including the international banks and funds behind projects like Skouries — that a project is contested; it draws the European eye; and it creates a public record. On Greece's biggest fights, sustained national and international coverage has been part of the pressure.

Build the Story Around People, Place, and Proof

The most powerful Greek stories combine a human and natural face with a documented fact: a forest and a community against an open-pit mine; a river and its valley against a diversion the courts have condemned; a protected island against a resort. Lead with the people and the place; supply the proof; keep it accurate. Prepare a few clear, repeatable messages — what the project is, what it would destroy, what rule was broken, what you are asking — and keep every spokesperson on them.

Reach Every Layer

Local and regional media reach the affected community and its officials. **National outlets and Greece's environmental journalists** carry the fight to the country and to decision-makers. **European and international media** matter where EU law, a foreign investor, or international financiers are involved — coverage in Brussels and abroad reaches the Commission and the markets. **Social media and your own channels** mobilise quickly and directly — strongest when anchored to verified facts and the slower legal and organising work.

Discipline and Safety

Be accurate always; one exaggeration handed to the other side can discredit a campaign, and in a defamation-prone environment can expose you, so verify before you publish and correct fast. Stay on message. Anticipate the counter-narrative — that opponents are against jobs, investment, or the national interest — and pre-empt it by grounding everything in law, EU obligations, water, health, heritage, and the community's own stake. Protect the people who speak, especially at flashpoints where activists have been policed and prosecuted: share the spokesperson role, and never let a photo opportunity pull participants into a confrontation whose legal risk they did not choose. Used with discipline, media is the amplifier that makes every other lever — legal, European, political — hit harder.

Amplifying at Scale — Media Help for Hire

Beyond pitching reporters yourselves, you can pay to spread the story at scale — different from a single advert or one call to a local outlet, and available at any reach from local to global. **Public-relations and communications firms** run earned-media campaigns — placing op-eds, orchestrating coverage, staging the media push; for the cause side, public-interest firms such as Fenton, BerlinRosen and M+R work for advocacy groups and unions, not only corporations. **Press-release / newswire distribution services** send a release across a wide network of journalists and outlets — PR Newswire, Business Wire and GlobeNewswire at the global, higher-budget end; EIN Presswire, PRWeb and eReleases far cheaper and nonprofit-friendly, some with cause-specific wires. And **digital and social amplification** shops run targeted paid campaigns and creator partnerships. Two rules: amplify a *true* story from a *real* community — never manufacture fake outrage; and where public visibility is dangerous, favour trusted journalists and international allies over paid amplification.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you enter objections, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — domestic and European. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law and the evidence.

8A. Objection During the EIA Public Consultation

To: the competent authority (the Ministry of Environment and Energy / the decentralised administration) **Subject:** Objection — [project], environmental procedure [ref]

As a person concerned by [project] at [location], I object during the public-consultation stage. My grounds, with evidence: (1) the environmental-impact study [omits / understates] [effect]; (2) [a Natura 2000 site / a water body] is affected and no adequate appropriate assessment was carried out, contrary to the Habitats [and Water Framework] Directive; (3) [the consultation / publicity] was defective. I request that the Approval of Environmental Terms be REFUSED, or that [strict conditions and a redesign] be required, and that this objection be entered on the record. [Attachments.]

8B. Environmental-Information Request (Aarhus)

To: [the competent authority] **Subject:** Request for environmental information — [project]

Under the right of access to environmental information (the Aarhus Convention and Greek implementing law), please provide: the environmental-impact study and any appropriate assessment; the Approval of Environmental Terms and its conditions and publication date; the monitoring data; the record of public participation; and the correspondence between [the authority] and [the developer]. Please respond within the statutory period; if access is refused, please state the legal basis, which I may challenge.

8C. Petition for Annulment at the Council of State (via counsel)

To: the Council of State (Symvoulío tis Epikrateias), via counsel **Subject:** Petition for annulment (aitisi akiroseos) of [the AEPO / the plan] [ref]

As [affected persons / a municipality / an environmental NGO with standing], we petition for annulment of [the decision], published on [date], on the grounds that [the EIA was inadequate / the appropriate assessment was missing or defective, contrary to the Habitats Directive / the project breaches the Water Framework Directive / the consultation was unlawful / it offends Article 24 of the Constitution]. We request suspension of the decision pending judgment, and, where relevant, a reference to the Court of Justice of the European Union on [the EU-law question]. [Filed within the statutory deadline. Grounds and evidence attached.]

8D. Complaint to the European Commission

To: the European Commission (environmental complaints) **Subject:** Complaint — Greece's breach of EU environmental law at [location]

We submit that Greece is breaching [the EIA Directive / the Habitats and Birds Directives and the Natura 2000 obligations / the Water Framework Directive] in connection with [project] at [location]. The facts, with evidence: [documented breach]. Domestic remedies [have failed / are inadequate], as shown by [attached]. We ask the Commission to investigate and, if warranted, open infringement proceedings against Greece.

8E. Letter to the Authority or the Ministry

To: [the Ministry of Environment and Energy / the decentralised administration / the region] **Subject:** [Refuse / suspend / reconsider] [project] [ref]

We are residents of [place] writing about [project]. Our concern, briefly: [one or two specific grounds — an EU-law breach, a defective EIA, a Natura 2000 or water impact]. We ask you to [specific, achievable action]. [If true:] [#] residents, [#] organisations, and [the municipality] share this concern; the decision carries legal and financial risk, including annulment and EU infringement. We welcome a meeting and can share our full evidence.

8F. Referral to the Ombudsman or Prosecutor

To: the Greek Ombudsman (Synigoros tou Politi) / the competent prosecutor **Subject:** Referral — [maladministration / suspected corruption] in [project], [location]

We bring to your attention [maladministration in the permitting of / documented facts suggesting corruption in connection with] [project]: [sourced facts only — approvals granted against the evidence, undisclosed interests, procedural abuse]. We attach the documentation and request an investigation. We confine this to what we can evidence and make no accusation beyond it.

8G. Coalition Outreach Email (to an environmental NGO)

To: [WWF Greece / Greenpeace Greece / MedINA / Callisto] **Subject:** [Project] — would you bring or support a Council of State petition?

We are a community group in [place] working on [project], which [one-line stake — e.g. "would clear protected forest and harm a Natura 2000 site"]. We are getting in touch because your organisation has the standing, the lawyers, and the experience to challenge such approvals and complain to the Commission. We are not asking you to adopt our whole campaign — just to consider [a Council of State petition on the EU-law grounds / advising on the strongest grounds and the deadline]. We have documented evidence and community support and can share a brief and arrange a call.

8H. Email to a Reporter

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — Council of State / decision [date]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something in [place] your readers should know, with a clear news hook: [the environmental study / documents] show [quantified finding — e.g. "the assessment never properly evaluated the protected habitat the project borders"], and [the authority / the Council of State] is [deciding / hearing] on [date]. It's new, specific, and time-sensitive. I can share the full file and connect you with [an expert]. Could we talk this week?

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — above all the AEPO's publication date, which starts the Council of State clock. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law and the evidence; attach your documentation; and route them, where you can, through or with an experienced environmental NGO that can strengthen the framing and carry the petition and the European complaint. The reply — or the silence — becomes part of your record, and in Greece that record feeds the two arenas that matter most: the Council of State and the European Commission.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With an afternoon a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Find the AEPO's publication date — today.** The Council of State deadline is short and strict, and missing it can end a good case before it starts. Identify the date, and get a lawyer or an NGO onto the timeline at once. This is the single most time-critical move in Greece.
- 2. Object during the EIA public consultation, before it closes.** One page naming one or two concrete grounds — a defective assessment, a Natura 2000 or water impact — puts your objection on the record and preserves your position.
- 3. Request the environmental file.** One environmental-information request (8B) forces out the study, the approval, and the correspondence — often revealing the defect that becomes your case.
- 4. Complain to the European Commission.** If a specific EU rule is being broken — the EIA, Habitats, Natura 2000, or Water Framework obligations — a complaint to Brussels (8D) engages a referee no local interest can capture. It costs only the writing.
- 5. Hand the fight to an environmental NGO.** WWF Greece, Greenpeace Greece, MedINA, Callisto and their European partners have the lawyers, the standing, and the channel to Brussels — point them at your project (8G) and they may carry the petition.
- 6. Get your municipality to petition.** A municipality has standing at the Council of State; persuading yours to petition adds real weight.
- 7. Tell one reporter.** Greece's environmental journalists cover these stories; a single accurate tip (8H) can raise the cost and reach a lawyer.

Do only the first four and you will have protected the deadline, put your objection on the record, forced out the file, and put the case in front of Europe. Then come back and read the rest.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Greece's system is tilted in places — toward investment and jobs after years of economic crisis, and toward large investors

the state treats as strategic. You must understand the tilt precisely, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that reach past it.

Where the Tilt Shows

Governments want investment and jobs, and can align firmly with a well-financed investor on a flagship project. Economic crisis has, at times, eroded the public will to resist and made communities dependent on the very projects they once fought — the Skouries story, where opposition weakened as jobs became scarce. Permitting authorities can be under political pressure. And at flashpoints, the state has met protest with heavy policing and prosecutions. Where the tilt is this deep, the domestic process alone cannot be relied on — but powerful levers still reach past it.

What Still Works — And It Is Strong

The decisive point about Greece is that even where the system tilts, a powerful set of levers reaches past it — because Greece is bound by EU law and has an independent supreme court.

EU environmental law is a ceiling the tilt cannot breach. The EIA, Habitats, and Water Framework Directives bind Greece regardless of local pressure, and a breach is enforceable by the European Commission and the CJEU — bodies no Greek interest can capture. This is the ground on which Acheloos was struck down.

The Council of State is independent. It applies EU and constitutional law, has annulled major projects, and can refer questions to the CJEU. It is domestic, but not captured — though it operates under a short deadline and does not always rule your way.

International scrutiny raises the cost. European NGOs, the international press, and the financiers behind big projects are sensitive to a state's EU standing and reputation, and to a project's legal risk.

Endurance can outlast the tilt. Acheloos was won over decades of relentless legal and public pressure. Where a project is a flagship, the realistic aim may be delay, conditions, and a durable movement — which can still, over time, change the outcome.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Greece is real but not romantic. Where a project depends on an approval you can challenge on EU-law grounds, the courts and the Commission give a community genuine power, and Acheloos proves they can win outright. Where the state and a well-financed investor are determined and the economy presses jobs, the fight is far harder, the domestic process tilts, and even a fierce movement can be worn down — the Skouries warning. But even then the EU lever, the independent court, and international pressure carry real weight, and endurance can change what a single push cannot. Diagnose the tilt honestly, reach for the European referee the local interests cannot capture, file on time, and build to last.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Most bad decisions are lawful decisions you disagree with. But genuine corruption exists in Greece — in permitting, in public works, in the awarding of concessions — and recognising it tells you which lever works and which is closed. Handle it carefully: the same facts that can sink a project can expose you to a defamation suit if you get them wrong.

Signs of Capture

Watch for the patterns: an approval granted against the clear weight of the evidence; a spatial plan changed quietly to enable a project; undisclosed interests linking officials and beneficiaries; a project treated as untouchable regardless of its legal defects; procedural rules bent to speed a favoured investor. At its harder edge, capture can mean a state so aligned with a strategic investor that the ordinary checks stop functioning — and, at flashpoints, the criminalisation of the community's protest.

Why This Changes Your Strategy

Where corruption or deep capture protects the harm, persuading the captured domestic body is futile. The strategy shifts

to the levers that reach past the capture:

- **The European Commission and EU law.** The Commission is a referee the domestic capture cannot reach; document the EU-law breach and take it to Brussels.
- **The Council of State.** Independent of the government, it can annul an unlawful approval whatever the political will behind it — if you file on time and on solid EU-law grounds.
- **The Ombudsman and prosecutors.** The Greek Ombudsman can investigate maladministration, and prosecutors can pursue genuine corruption — on evidence, not accusation.
- **Investigative journalism and international pressure.** A documented story, and the attention of European partners and financiers, can move what a captured body will not.

Document It Carefully and Safely

If you are documenting corruption or capture, do so with rigour and restraint. Distinguish always between what you can prove and what you suspect; allege only what your evidence supports; and refer serious allegations through lawyers and the proper bodies (the Ombudsman, the prosecutors, the European Commission), not through reckless public accusation, which invites a defamation suit and hands your opponents the story. Protect yourself and your community: where protest has been policed and prosecuted, arrange legal support in advance and act collectively. In Greece, documented illegality — carried to the Council of State and the European Commission — is how the capture is reached, and doing the work carefully and collectively is how a community sustains the fight.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps in this guide are not a menu to pick from; they are strands to weave together over time, with the European lever running through everything and the court deadline governing the pace. This section shows how they combine, and roughly when each comes into play.

How the Strands Reinforce Each Other

The power of a Greek campaign comes from combining its strands and running the domestic and European tracks together. **Documentation** feeds everything — the court petition, the European complaint, the media. **The EU-law case** is the thread that runs through every argument and reaches past any domestic tilt. **The Council of State** applies that law at home, on a short clock; **the European Commission and the CJEU** enforce it against the state. **Organisation and endurance** supply the political weight and the staying power a long fight demands. **Media and NGOs** raise the cost and carry the case. Each strand strengthens the others: a documented Natura 2000 breach becomes a Council of State petition, a European complaint, a news story, and a mobilising cause at once. No single strand reliably wins the hardest fights; woven together, and anchored in Europe, they have won Greece's greatest ones — as long as the deadline is met and the effort is sustained.

A Rough Timeline

Early (first weeks) — and this is urgent. Identify the project and the AEPO's publication date, because the Council of State deadline is short. Engage a lawyer or an NGO immediately. Begin documentation; request the environmental file; object during any open consultation. Establish the EU-law angle — the EIA, the Natura 2000 status, the water impact — early, because it is your firmest ground.

Building (weeks to months). File the Council of State petition within the deadline, and in parallel the complaint to the European Commission. Deepen the documentation and the legal analysis. Build the coalition wide — residents, NGOs, the municipality — and the media presence, and begin sustained public mobilisation, built to last.

Sustained (months to years). Keep the two legal tracks, the organising, the media, and the European engagement alive together, adapting as the situation shifts. Sustain the people through a long fight — the Acheloos lesson is that persistence over years is what wins, and the Skouries lesson is that a movement worn down loses. Guard against burnout and economic pressure by sharing the load and keeping the legal case moving.

Throughout. Reassess honestly. If a lever works, press it; if a flagship project grinds on despite real effort, shift the aim to delay, conditions, and a durable movement, and keep the European complaint and the record live. And keep the EU lever central at every step: in Greece, the law of Europe, applied by an independent court and enforced by referees the local interests cannot capture, is the firmest ground a community stands on.

Two Fights, Two Lessons

Greece offers a community two case studies, and together they are the most honest teaching in this guide. **Acheloos is the lesson of what the levers can win.** A river diversion treated as a national priority by every government was defeated by decades of relentless litigation at the Council of State and a CJEU ruling that it breached EU water and habitats law — proof that the courts and Europe, used patiently and on solid EU-law grounds, can beat even a project the state is determined to build. **Skouries is the lesson of the limits.** A gold and copper mine in Halkidiki drew one of Europe's fiercest community movements — years of protest, occupation, and litigation from 2012 — and was still re-approved in 2021, financed, and built, entering production as economic crisis eroded the movement, the state stood with the investor, and protest was policed and prosecuted. The lesson: the same toolkit that won Acheloos was not enough at Skouries, because determination, money, jobs, and time were all on the other side. Hold both. File on time, build the EU-law case, organise broadly — and build to endure, because in Greece the difference between winning and losing has often been persistence.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Honest Bottom Line

Greece is, for a community facing a destructive project, a country of real and proven tools — and of hard, honest limits. Both are true, and which you meet depends on the fight.

Where a project depends on an environmental approval you can challenge on EU-law grounds, Greece's membership of the European Union gives a community genuinely powerful levers. **EU environmental law — the EIA, Habitats, Birds, and Water Framework Directives — binds the Greek state and cannot be lawfully overridden.** The **Council of State**, an independent supreme court, applies that law and has struck down major projects, and it can refer questions to the **Court of Justice of the European Union**. Greece has proved these levers can win outright: the decades-long fight against the **Acheloos River diversion** — overturned again and again by the Council of State and condemned by the CJEU under EU water and habitats law — defeated a project every government treated as a priority.

But Greece also shows the limits. The **Skouries** gold and copper mine drew one of Europe's most committed community movements — years of protest, occupation, and litigation — and was still re-approved, financed, and built, entering production two decades after the fight began. The state stayed aligned with the investor, economic crisis eroded the movement, and protest itself was met with heavy policing and prosecutions. The levers were used, and they did not stop it. That is the honest warning a Greek community must carry: the tools are real and have won, but against a determined, well-financed, state-backed project, they are not guaranteed.

What Distinguishes the Campaigns That Win

The Greek campaigns that succeed share a pattern. They **file on time** — the Council of State deadline is short and strict, and a missed date defeats a good case. They anchor everything in **EU law** and take it to both the Council of State and the European Commission. They document rigorously, because every referee acts on evidence. They organise broadly — residents, NGOs, and the municipality together — and, above all, they **endure**, because Acheloos was won over decades and Skouries was lost as its movement was worn down. The campaigns that come to grief miss the deadline, rely on a determined domestic process alone, or exhaust their people before the levers can work.

A Closing Word

If you are reading this because a project threatens your forest, your river, your island, or your town, understand that in Greece you are not without recourse — and that you stand in the country whose courts and EU law defeated a river diversion every government wanted. The method is clear: find the approval's publication date and act within the deadline; build the case on EU and Greek law; take it to the Council of State and, decisively, to the European Commission; document everything; organise broadly; and, above all, endure. It does not promise an easy win, and against a flagship, state-backed project it asks you to accept real limits — Skouries is honest about that. But it is the method by which Greek communities and their lawyers, over decades and against every government, defeated the Acheloos diversion — and it is the firmest ground a community can stand on. Judge your campaign by real outcomes — an approval annulled, a consent quashed on EU-law grounds, a European finding, a project delayed or redesigned — file on time, organise to last, and hold to the knowledge that here the law of Europe, applied by an independent court, has stopped what governments wanted built.

Real Outcomes: What Winning Looks Like

"Winning" in Greece takes several forms, and it is worth naming them so you recognise one when it comes: an **Approval of Environmental Terms annulled** by the Council of State, sending the project back or ending it; a **consent quashed on Natura 2000 or Water Framework grounds**, as Greek NGOs and the Acheloos litigants achieved; a **CJEU ruling** that a project breaches EU law and binds the state; a **plan withdrawn or struck down** — as challenges to plans permitting resorts inside Natura 2000 islands have shown; a **European Commission finding or infringement action**; a **project delayed and redesigned** until it becomes uneconomic; or, against a flagship, **conditions, delay, and a durable movement** even where an outright stop proves out of reach. Communities in Greece have achieved each of these — almost always through the combination of documentation, the Council of State, the European lever, organisation, and endurance, and rarely through any single step. And be honest that some fights, like Skouries, are lost even so. Judge your campaign by these outcomes, and remember that the greatest of them, Acheloos, took decades and relentless persistence.